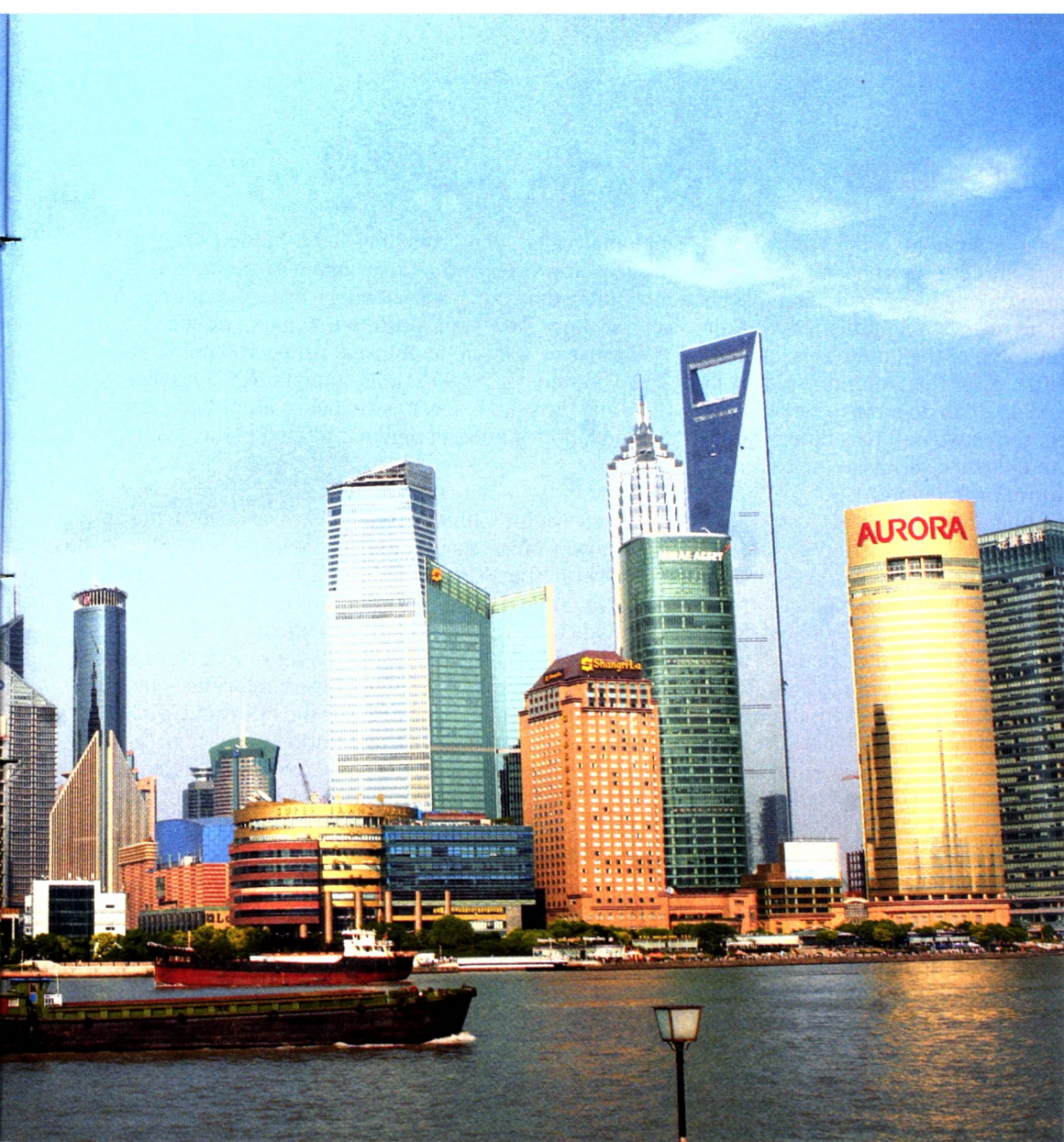




SHAILESH RAVAL

“ The living conditions in my village have vastly improved under the new countryside programme and there is now new hope for my husband and two children. ”

WANG YA FEN
Farmer's wife
Donghan
village, Xian



“ Although we are partly owned by the Government, we take decisions about importing equipment or retaining workers. We do well because there is very little interference. ”

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FISH WHICH COST Rs 57 LAKH EACH AND ARE SAID TO EXUDE 'GOOD ENERGY'.

village become for its paintings that it is now more known for its exhibitions of art than farming. Over an elaborate Chinese meal that involves several courses and massive amounts of food going waste, Wang Ya Fen, the wife of one of the farmers, says: "Living conditions have vastly improved for us and there is new hope for my husband and two children. We now have no fears at all."

At the village office lined with boards containing charts and figures, a bevy of stern-looking officials headed by Guo Junliang, director of the Huxian County's New Countryside Programme, sit down to discuss their plans for Donghan and the other 517 villages and six towns that come under their jurisdiction. Though it has loosened controls, the Chinese Government continues to monitor rural communities through an elaborate network called the household production responsibility system. Junliang says the focus is on improving production efficiency in agriculture, building infrastructure and encouraging farmers and their families to turn to agri-business products or to work in the dominant industries in the region. "Our idea is to increase

incomes of rural households substantially and help them integrate into industries and reduce unproductive labour in farming," says Junliang.

In Fang Jhia Zhai village, not far from Donghan village, if one drives beyond the main street of painted compound walls, the facade begins to drop. The village office looks newly built but most houses are still dilapidated, the paintings on the top of their doorways peeling off. At the village square, farmers sit idling while others play a game of cards as their children do wheelies on their cycles. There are signs of prosperity though with villagers moving around on new motorbikes. Solar heaters dot the roofs of the more recently renovated houses. The village grows wheat as its main crop and also kiwi fruit. Framed against a fiery dragon statue at the village shrine, Chengen Liang, the village party secretary, says: "We have waited too long for all this to happen. The key is sustainability."

Whether Donghan or Fang Jhia Zhai represent Potemkin-like villages or are genuine examples of the new countryside will hold the key to China's future stability and